

“Open source is a challenge as well as a great opportunity”

Krishnakant Mane is an inspirational figure not just in the FOSS universe, but also beyond that. Undeterred by his visual impairment, he has gone on to blaze trails in the world of accessibility and OSS. He believes that, “Vision is more important than sight. And knowledge is more important than information.”

M eet Krishnakant Mane, an open source advocate, first blind IT professional in India and the only the third in Asia. He is also the founder of the Digital Freedom Foundation, an organisation dedicated to bringing freedom of technology in education. The foundation also takes up projects on rural digital empowerment and setting up ICT based infrastructure.

Besides these activities, the foundation actively participates in the development of free and open source software (FOSS) for the education, health and finance sectors.

The foundation also challenged the State and Central government asking why proprietary brands are used in text books and after the court case, Maharashtra state board has removed the brand names and now open source alternatives have taken their place in 11th standard text books.

How ‘love at first encounter’ turned into a life’s mission

For Krishnakant, popularly known as KK in the open source community, FOSS means ‘Free as in freedom and not free of cost.’

“FOSS gives the much-needed digital freedom to me and anyone who is using it. There is total transparency in the software and given that it is an open platform for developers and users alike, everyone has a say. Basically, it’s digital democracy,” says KK.

KK’s first encounter with open source was in 2005 when he started using the shell with Emacs. He was then a well-established IT professional working on a number of high-end projects.

“I had heard about Linux but never used it. I got the opportunity to try it out in one of the Linux user group meetings, and the person doing the demo was Dr Nagarjun from the Homi Bhabha Centre for Science Education,” KK recalls.

Not only did KK discover the various accessibility options that FOSS offered, but he was able to see how cost-effective and powerful open source software is.

From then on, KK started to pay more attention to the developments happening in the FOSS world. Today, it has become his life’s mission to replace costly proprietary programs with open source alternatives.

“Emacspeak was my first screen reader-cum-audio desktop. It was developed by T.V. Raman who is



himself visually impaired. Orca, the professional quality screen reader is what I use day in and day out. I was deeply involved in the initial stages of its development,” KK says proudly.

Through his NGO, Digital Freedom Foundation, KK is also trying to bring about freedom of choice in the technology used in education, by introducing free software, as he believes “digital freedom is fundamental to life.”

The people behind KK’s success

Starting with Dr Nagarjun, there are many people who played significant roles in strengthening KK’s connect with FOSS. These include Dr Jaijit Bhattacharya from Sun Microsystems; Valsa Villiams, former director of Intel (whom he has immense respect for); Sunil Abraham from Computer Internet Society (CSI), and Dr Richard Stallman, with whom KK spent several exciting days when he came to India.

Thanks to these visionaries, today KK has become a source of inspiration for many students and aspiring programmers.

Working as a professional FOSS consultant for more than 10 years, KK